

AA: How crucial is the Bharat cell to your plans of putting Ola and India on the global map?

A: One of the big changes in our lives is that the energy paradigm is going from a petroleum paradigm... [which is] mine the oil, take it out, refine it and then burn it... It's going from that to renewable generation and energy storage... a technology paradigm. And that's where India has an opportunity to get into the cutting edge of this technology revolution.

We set up our cell effort four years ago when we started Ola Electric. [Then] we had decided to build the frontier technology in cells... and that was the 4680 format. It's much bigger, more energy dense, and [takes] much lesser time to charge... And from here on, we can go into solid state cells, etc., which are the Holy Grail of energy storage in the modern world.

The world has about 2,000 GWh of production capacity; almost 90% of that is in China in terms of cells. India has 1.5 GWh, that is mine [Ola's giga factory]. I hope to set up about 100 GWh through the course of this decade... India for its own energy transition in grid storage as well as automotive, will need about 1,000 GWh by the end of this decade or next decade, and we should aim to build all of that in India, and have more to sell to the world.

30 |

SM & AA: How much of a pricing difference will having your own cell make? How is life after the FAME subsidy?

A: The cell is the costliest component of an EV. It's the heart of an EV... because the cell defines the weight, range, charging speed... and costs about one-third the price of the vehicle. **If we make our own [cell], we will be able to make it about 25-30% cheaper.**

On FAME, the subsidy has reduced significantly in the past two years and the government has indicated a tapering off... in another two to three years, industry will be able to stand without any FAME subsidy.

RAHUL KANWAL, EDITORIAL DIRECTOR,

BUSINESS TODAY: You just became a billionaire. But you claim that you've never invested in the stock markets before. Can you explain that?

A: I have never bought a single share in my life. I've only built value in the shares through my companies... Whatever money we had taken off the table as liquidity so far was in savings bank accounts, FDs, etc. But now I'm learning the ways of the market. Now that I have some more liquidity, I intend to make some smart bets in the market.



“The scale of our data is our strength... The whole stack of data management needs to be—through policy and implementation—brought into India”

But net worth is just a notional number. It's not as if the money is in my bank... I still spend, and hope to spend all my weekends in my factory working on new products with my engineering teams, building new things. That's what gives me satisfaction, and that's what drives me.

RK: What are you looking to spend your money on?

A: More factories, more data centres, more tech, more AI.

AA: How do you respond to comparisons with Tesla CEO Elon Musk?

A: I am just myself. He's somebody we all look up to. But I don't know why he does the businesses that I do (laughs)... I'm serious; I started Krutrim before he started his AI venture. If Silicon Valley people can wear leather jackets and black polo T shirts, why can't we wear our kurtas and have long hair? **BT**

@TheSouravM, @aayush_a6

For the full event coverage, turn to Page 184